‘Sir, we need to launch an operation. If we can bring down Khan and Sandhu together, it will have an adverse effect on all those standing in the queue to bleed us,’ Jindal responded.

‘Do you want me to launch an operation without knowing fully how to handle and operate it? I am also worried about the access of your agent, whether or not he has the keys to the inner circle of Khan and his chums. I won’t allow it without proper control.’ Bhardwaj’s reaction was sharp.

‘Give me a couple of days and I will respond to your queries in detail. We must do something urgently and I promise not to disappoint you,’ Jindal assured him.

Bhardwaj had been told by a friend in the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) that they were working out Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi’s future visits abroad and France could be one of the destinations in 1985. Thinking about Jindal’s confidence in the intelligence he had received, Bhardwaj made up his mind that if any operation was going to be launched, London had to be the theatre and Paris could be used as an intelligence sub-station to plan the operation and hold meetings.

According to an intelligence analysis, India’s relations with France had been rather formal for many years after Independence as it was the only European country to have a colonial pocket remaining in India after the Portuguese left Goa. Both countries had been too preoccupied with their respective problems to pay much attention to each other: France was deep in the task of post-war rehabilitation and reconstruction and India needed to build up a partitioned country. The world outlook of the two countries also differed substantially. India was non-aligned while France became a member of the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation in 1949. These differences were